[Experiment, Analysis, and Benchmark] Filtered Vector Search Under Updates: When Does an Index Beat a Scan?

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***Abstract*—Vector databases answer nearest-neighbor queries with attribute filters over data that is continuously inserted and deleted, yet filtered search has been evaluated almost exclusively on static data. We study eleven methods from nine families on SIFT, DEEP, YFCC, and 4096-dimensional arXiv collections of up to 10^7 vectors, with controlled and real predicates, three synthetic update streams and one with real temporal drift, and inside PostgreSQL and Milvus. Two lessons emerge. First, the cheapest access path depends on conditions that benchmarks usually fix. The admissible-set size at which an index overtakes an exact scan grows with the collection ($n^{0.41}$ to $n^{0.64}$ for IVF, ACORN, and post-filtering), so a dispatch threshold fixed as a size or a selectivity—Milvus switches at 7%—picks the slower path at some collection sizes, while one scaled with $\sqrt{n}$ transferred to other sizes; and the cheapest method over a stream depends on the query-to-update ratio and the data: a label-partitioned IVF on our synthetic streams at every tested ratio, graph indexes on the drifting arXiv stream from about one query per update. Second, deletions break filtered search in different ways. Tombstoned ACORN loses recall when deletions correlate with the attribute (1.000→0.575), and repairing its lists on every level restores it (0.997–0.998, 5 runs) but lowers recall under uniform deletions on DEEP-5M, unless the repair keeps a node's live neighbors in place; EMA's implemented synchronous deletion keeps recall but loses 5.3× throughput; IVF's exact deletions keep both at two to three orders of magnitude less maintenance, but its throughput drifts with the data unless it is retrained. A cost model frames the scan crossover as a $\sqrt{n}$ lower bound for indexes that check inadmissible points (independent admissibility) and the rebuild period as an economic order quantity. We release all artifacts.**

***Index Terms*—vector search, approximate nearest neighbor search, filtered search, hybrid queries, dynamic indexing, benchmark**

I. Introduction

Vector databases answer nearest-neighbor queries that carry attribute predicates—"similar products *in stock*", "passages *from this tenant*"—over collections that change continuously. A large body of recent work builds indexes for one of these two requirements: filter-aware graphs that keep navigation inside a predicate [1], [2], [3] or fold attribute mismatch into the graph distance [4], range-filter structures [5], [6], [7], and streaming indexes that absorb insertions and deletions [8], [9], [10]. Experimental studies have compared filtered methods on static data [11], [12], [13], [14], [15], and benchmarks have exercised streaming insertions and deletions [16] and continuous insertion [17], without filters. A deployment, however, faces both at once, and the experimental study of Li et al. lists dynamic updates as an open problem for filtered search [12]. This paper evaluates filtered search *under updates*, against simple baselines—an exact scan, a bitmap-filtered IVF index, and a selectivity dispatcher—that are easy to deploy alongside any index.

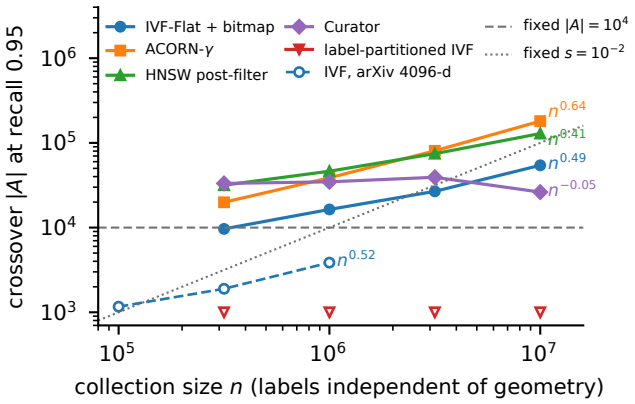


Fig. 1. Where an index catches up with an exact per-label scan, as the collection grows (recall 0.95, labels independent of geometry; DEEP subsets, and IVF on 4096-dimensional arXiv embeddings). Above its curve an index beats the scan. A dispatch threshold stated as a fixed admissible-set size (dashed) or a fixed selectivity (dotted) crosses the curves, so it does not track the measured crossover. Exponents of log–log fits; hollow markers: the index already wins at the smallest measured size (10^3).

The crossover moves with the collection. Systems place the switch between a scan and an index with a fixed rule: pre-filter below a selectivity (Milvus 2.6: 7% [18], [19]; ACORN [1]), or scan rare tags linearly (the winning Big-ANN'23 filtered entry [16]). Mandarapu and Kunkunuru observed for pre- versus post-filtering under a fixed budget that the crossover selectivity falls as $1/\sqrt{n}$ [20]. We find that this extends across index families and decides which rule to deploy (Figure 1). Under independent admissibility (Section IV), an index that must check inadmissible points pays for each one it examines, so the admissible-set size at which it catches up with an exact scan has a lower bound that grows as $\sqrt{n}$; measured from $n{=}3.16\times10^5$ to 10^7 it grows as $n^{0.41}$–$n^{0.64}$ for IVF, ACORN, and post-filtering. Calibrated on DEEP-1M and applied unchanged to the other sizes, a fixed

admissible-set threshold picks the slower of scan and IVF on 2 of 17 workloads (up to 89% more cost) and Milvus's 7% rule, applied to the same choice, on 5 (up to 677%), while the same calibration scaled with $\sqrt{n}$ picks right on all 17; on arXiv, where distances cost more relative to checks, the scaled threshold also needs the measured check-to-distance cost ratio (mean regret 6% with it, 31% without). Indexes that never touch an inadmissible point escape the growth: a label-partitioned IVF beats the scan from 10^3 admissible points up at every n. Updates add a second mechanism—under correlated deletions an in-filter graph loses the routes its search takes into a label's region—and the rest of the paper measures both.

We ask six questions. **Q1**: When does an index beat an exact scan of the admissible points, and is the crossover a function of the admissible-set size $s \cdot n$? **Q2**: How does the correlation between attributes and geometry reorder the methods? **Q3**: What happens on real predicates whose selectivity spans orders of magnitude? **Q4**: How do accuracy, throughput, footprint, and maintenance evolve as the data churns, and what if deletions correlate with the attribute? **Q5**: Which method is cheapest once maintenance and queries are both paid for? **Q6**: Which evaluation practices change the conclusions?

Summary of findings. (1) *A crossover that grows with* n (Sections IV, V-A). From n=3.16 $\times$ 10^5 to 10^7 it grows as $n^{0.49}$ for IVF, $n^{0.64}$ for ACORN, and $n^{0.41}$ for post-filtering, and not for Curator ($n^{-0.05}$), stably across passes and against a one-query-per-call scan; on arXiv IVF's exponent recurs ($n^{0.52}$). (2) Correlation reorders the methods—post-filtering fails to reach recall 0.95 with correlated attributes, a label-specialized graph succeeds—but only when queries ask for labels far from where they lie. (3) On YFCC-10M's tag predicates none of the indexes we evaluate there reaches recall 0.99 alone within its swept parameters; with a tuned selectivity dispatcher every index does, and Curator for selective predicates paired with IVF or a graph for common ones is fastest; on 500 held-out queries only scan plus IVF still holds 0.99. A Roaring bitmap index makes the predicates 105$\times$ cheaper to evaluate. (4) *Deletions break search in different ways* (Section VI). ACORN, which deletes only through its predicate, collapses (maximum recall 1.000→0.575) when deletions correlate with the attribute, long before its admissible subgraph fragments; a repair of every level restores it (0.997–0.998, 5 runs) but lowers recall under uniform deletions on DEEP-5M when it re-ranks a node's live neighbors; refilling only the deleted slots avoids that. EMA's synchronous deletion keeps recall on every stream but loses 5.3$\times$ throughput under correlated deletions. Deleting by age on arXiv breaks no graph. (5) *Total cost* (Section VII). At recall 0.95 a label-partitioned IVF is the cheapest method at every tested query-to-update ratio on the synthetic streams (0.22–0.39$\times$ IVF), while on arXiv graph indexes are cheapest from about one query per update. Executed over a stream, the rebuild period that Proposition 2 computes from another stream cost at most 5.7% more than the best executed period on the two SIFT streams (with the effort chosen per round), but a search effort fixed on the other stream did not hold recall 0.95. (6) Rankings depend on the setup: threads raise the crossover, contention changed throughputs by up to 2.9$\times$, ACORN's documented build compiles scalar kernels, and 30 of 177 index-versus-scan verdicts lie between the two measured points that bracket the recall target.

Contributions. A benchmark for filtered search under updates (Section III); a cost model whose crossover bound, reachability account, and rebuild rule were tested against criteria stated in advance, except for the checks of Section IX (Section IV); a study of eleven methods and two DBMSs on four update streams, one with real drift (Sections V–VII); evaluation lessons, including fixes for two ACORN defects and a repair for its deletions; and all artifacts.

II. Filtered Search and Its Update Paths

A filtered k-NN query asks for the k points nearest to q among the *admissible set* $A_p = \{x \in X : p(x)\}$ of a predicate p; its selectivity is $s = |A_p|/n$. We group the methods we evaluate into nine families by *where the predicate enters the search* and record, for each, *how it absorbs insertions and deletions* (Table I).

Pre-filter scan. Compute A_p, then scan it exactly. When the predicate is an equality on a label known at insertion time, the points of each label can be stored contiguously (*per-label partition*), so the scan touches only $|A_p|$ vectors; we also evaluate the general case in which A_p is an arbitrary bitmap and the scan visits all n rows and skips inadmissible ones (*bitmap scan*). Updates are appends and removals; there is nothing to repair.

Post-filter. Search an unfiltered index for $k' \geq k$ candidates and keep the admissible ones. We use hnswlib [21] with slot reuse for deletions. Post-filtering needs $k' \gtrsim k/s$ when admissible points are spread like the data, and fails when they are not.

Predicate-agnostic in-filter graph. ACORN-γ [1] builds an HNSW-like graph whose neighbor lists are expanded by a factor γ, so that the subgraph induced by an arbitrary predicate stays navigable; search visits only admissible nodes. Insertions use the graph's incremental `add`; ACORN has no deletion routine, so deleted points are excluded through the predicate bitmap and remain in the graph as routers. We also evaluate ACORN-1 (γ=1), its cheaper-to-build variant.

Label-specialized graph. Filtered-DiskANN [2] builds a Vamana graph whose pruning preserves, for every label, paths among the points carrying it, and starts each query from a per-label start point. It supports equality on build-time labels only. The public Python binding exposes no dynamic filtered index, so freshness requires rebuilding.

Label-indexed tree. Curator [22] builds one hierarchical clustering tree over all vectors and embeds a lightweight per-label index in it as a subtree; a point is indexed under a label by granting it the label, and a label search traverses that label's subtree. Other predicates, such as the AND of two tags, use its bitmap-filtered search. Insertion adds the vector to the tree and grants its labels. The released implementation rejects vector

TABLE I
METHOD FAMILIES, HOW EACH CONSUMES THE PREDICATE, AND HOW EACH ABSORBS UPDATES IN THE IMPLEMENTATIONS WE EVALUATE.

family	method (impl.)	predicate	insert	delete
pre-filter scan	per-label / bitmap (Faiss)	any†	append	remove
post-filter	HNSW (hnswlib)	any	add	slot reuse
in-filter graph	ACORN-γ, ACORN-1	any	add	bitmap exclusion
marker graph	EMA (authors' code)	DNF§	add	repair
label graph	Filtered-DiskANN (diskannpy)	eq. label	rebuild	rebuild
label tree	Curator	label‡	add+grant	revoke label
partition+bitmap	IVF-Flat (Faiss)	any	append	remove
label partition	label-partitioned IVF (Faiss)	eq. label	append	remove
regenerable pools	RIG (ours)	any	route+append	remove

†The per-label partition requires an equality predicate on a build-time label; the bitmap scan accepts any. ‡Other predicates through a bitmap-filtered search. §Numeric ranges and label sets; evaluated on the update streams only.

removal, so deletion revokes the point's labels: the vector stays in the tree, but no label search can return it.

Partition with bitmap. IVF-Flat [23] assigns points to the nearest of n_{list} k-means centroids and scans the n_{probe} lists nearest to the query, skipping inadmissible entries via a bitmap. With centroids fixed after training, insertion is an append to one list and deletion an exact removal; there are no tombstones and no graph to repair. Correlated predicates hurt IVF in a specific way: the admissible points may live in lists far from the query, so recall at a fixed n_{probe} drops.

Label-partitioned IVF. A design point that the cost model of Section IV suggests and that we add to the study: one IVF-Flat index per label over that label's points ($n_{\text{list}} = 4\sqrt{n_b}$ for a label with n_b points, each with its own k-means). A label search probes only that label's lists, so it never examines an inadmissible point, and insertion and deletion are exact, as in IVF. It requires an equality predicate on a build-time label.

Marker graph (EMA). EMA [24] attaches to each HNSW edge a small signature of the attributes reachable through it, so that filtered search skips edges that cannot lead to admissible points, and deletes by an IP-DiskANN-style in-place edge repair [10], extended to the signatures (the preprint describes lazy batched deletion; the public code we run repairs inside each deletion call). We run the authors' code (commit d95fb49) with the parameters of their dynamic experiments (M=40, ef_c=300).

Regenerable pool index. RIG, a design point of our own (unpublished), stores no adjacency lists: points belong to overlapping pools from hash-priority ball carving, and neighbors are recomputed at query time inside the predicate. Its state is a function of the point set, which gives exact deletions; its dynamic path routes insertions down a fixed leader tree and compacts every round.

III. BENCHMARK DESIGN

Datasets and predicates. We use SIFT1M [25] (n=10^6, d=128) and DEEP [26] (both as distributed by ANN-Benchmarks [27]) at 10^6, 3.16×10^6, and 10^7 points (d=96, normalized; the two smaller sets are fixed random subsets of DEEP-10M, so that n varies without changing the distribution), and YFCC-10M from the filtered track of the NeurIPS'23 Big-ANN competition [16], derived from YFCC100M [28] (n=10^7, d=192), whose points carry real tag sets and whose queries ask for the AND of one or two tags. On SIFT and DEEP we generate label predicates with two controlled knobs. Each point receives one of $L = 1/s$ labels, defined by quantiles of $\beta\, z(x) + (1-\beta)\,\varepsilon$, where $z(x)$ is the standardized projection $\langle x, w\rangle$ on a fixed random direction w and ε is standard Gaussian noise, so that s sets the selectivity and $\beta \in [0,1]$ controls the correlation between label and geometry (β=0: independent labels; β=1: slabs along w); each query asks for one uniformly random label. We use $s \in \{0.5, 0.1, 0.01\}$ and $\beta \in \{0, 0.5, 0.9, 1\}$. On YFCC we use 500 fixed random public queries; their selectivities range from 7.4×10^{-6} (74 admissible points) to 0.19, with 10th, 50th, and 90th percentiles of 2.2×10^{-5}, 1.3×10^{-3}, and 8.1×10^{-2}, and our exact filtered ground truth matches the official one on all of them.

Update streams. Three synthetic streams combine filtered queries (β=0.9, s=0.1) with churn, and a fourth orders real data by time. *SIFT-500K*: SIFT descriptors drawn from BIGANN [29] (1.5×10^6 distinct vectors, 500 BIGANN queries), 5×10^5 live points, 20 rounds, each deleting 10% of the live points uniformly at random and inserting 5×10^4 unseen points (200% turnover). *DEEP-5M*: 5×10^6 live points, 10 rounds of 10% deletions and 4.99×10^5 insertions of unseen DEEP vectors (100% turnover). A third stream, *SIFT-500K-adv*, tests correlation $\times$ churn: it is SIFT-500K with the same insertions and queries, but each round deletes the 10% of live points with the largest projection on the label direction w (plus small noise), so deletions empty the geometric regions of the highest labels first and the admissible sets of those labels shrink while others grow. *arXiv-time*: the arXiv embeddings ordered by the date of each paper's latest version; the 2×10^5 oldest are live at round 0, and each of 10 rounds inserts the next 4×10^4 papers and deletes the 4×10^4 oldest live ones. A paper's label is its first main category, mapped to the 9 most frequent categories of the initial window plus 'other' (so no later information enters the mapping), and the 500 queries are later papers asking for their own label, fixed across rounds—a stress test of drift, not a replay of arXiv's traffic. Exact filtered ground truth is recomputed over the live set after every round. As a control for the update paths, we also snapshot the live set of both SIFT streams after round 20 and build every method from scratch on it, with the same queries and ground truth. Every method applies every round through its own update path (Table I); search quality is measured at rounds $0, 4, \ldots, 20$ (SIFT) and $0, 5, 10$ (DEEP, arXiv).

Follow-up campaign. A second campaign under the same protocol tests the cost model; later sessions (repair variants, the label-partitioned IVF and EMA on the streams, the executed rebuild policies, the arXiv stream) each rerun IVF alongside and are combined with others only as ratios to that session's IVF. It runs in two passes, except the instrumented and repaired ACORN streams of Section VI (one to five runs, reported as ranges), the ACORN counting build, the DEEP-5M delta stream, each executed rebuild period, and each

added seed. It adds (i) an n-sweep with labels independent of geometry (β=0): DEEP subsets of 3.16×10^5, 10^6, 3.16×10^6, and 10^7 points with $|A_p| = n/L$ from about 10^3 to 3.16×10^5; (ii) query–filter correlation on SIFT1M (with probability $\rho \in \{0, 0.5, 1\}$ a query asks for its nearest neighbor's label); (iii) per-query counts of IVF's bitmap checks and distance computations and, in a separately compiled build, of ACORN's level-0 hops, checks, and distances; (iv) instrumented ACORN streams that record each label's live admissible subgraph, and a local repair of it; (v) dense sweeps (knob steps of $\sqrt{2}$) where conclusions depend on interpolation (Section VIII); (vi) PostgreSQL 16 with pgvector 0.8.1 (Section V-E; HNSW with m=32, ef_c=200, and IVFFlat with $4\sqrt{n}$ lists, both with iterative scans); and (vii) 4096-dimensional arXiv embeddings [14] (10^5, 3.16×10^5, and 10^6 points, 500 of the dataset's queries) with β=0 labels and, at 10^6, the real predicate "category includes the query's".

Parameters. Each method is swept over its search knob until recall exceeds 0.999 or a cap is reached: ACORN `efSearch` 16..2048, Filtered-DiskANN L 16..1024, IVF n_{probe} $8..\min(2048, n_{\text{list}}/2)$ with $n_{\text{list}} = 4\sqrt{n}$, post-filter $k' \in \{100, 400, 1600, 6400\}$ (streams: $\{400, 1600, 6400\}$), RIG ef 16..512; the same ranges apply to the streams. These sweeps, like the dispatcher thresholds of Section V-C, are evaluated on the reported queries, as is customary in ANN benchmarks; reported operating points are therefore tuned to the query set. Construction parameters follow the original papers' defaults: ACORN M=32, γ=12, M_β=64; Filtered-DiskANN R=64, L=100, α=1.2; HNSW M=32, ef$_c$=200.

Metrics. Every query asks for k=10 neighbors. Recall@10 of a query is the fraction of its exact filtered top-10 that is returned (over $\min(10, |A_p|)$ when fewer points are admissible), averaged over 500 queries; *maximum recall* is the highest recall in a method's parameter sweep, and QPS at a recall target is interpolated log-linearly on the method's recall–QPS Pareto frontier, except for the dispatcher of Section V-C, whose QPS is that of the best measured configuration (a concrete threshold and parameter) that reaches the target. QPS is the number of queries divided by the time spent inside the search calls of a single thread.

Measurement protocol. Searches are single-threaded and issue one query per call, with these exceptions: on label workloads ACORN and EMA are called once for all 500 queries (on one thread) and RIG once per label, and post-filtering, the bitmap scan, and the per-label scan are called once per label (the per-label scan is also reported per query); one call per label lets BLAS share work across queries. Some method-specific costs fall on the boundary of the timer: post-filtering's selection of admissible candidates (56 μs per query at k'=6400) and Filtered-DiskANN's check of the second tag of AND queries (73 μs at L=1024) are outside it, as is the Python call into RIG's C++ kernel (354 μs, which favors RIG); ACORN's one-query-per-call mode on YFCC allocates and clears an n-entry visited table inside it (0.40 ms per call, which disfavors ACORN on YFCC). The fixed cost of a Python binding call, timed inside the measurement for the per-query methods, is 12 μs for Faiss, 21 μs for `diskannpy`, and 8 μs for hnswlib, a median 2% of the query time over all measured operating points of these methods and at most 4% at recall ≥ 0.95. The predicate is handed to every method in its native precomputed form (label, bitmap, or admissible list), so predicate evaluation is not timed for any method; on YFCC it is not negligible—intersecting a query's tag lists takes 1.4 ms on average (p99 20.2 ms), and materializing the 10^7-entry mask and packing it into a bitmap another 1.2 and 0.6 ms—the intersection is needed by every method that receives an admissible list or bitmap (including the per-query scan), the mask and bitmap only by the bitmap-filtered methods. Static builds use 32 threads; in the streams, initial builds, update maintenance, and rebuilds use 16 threads, uniformly.

Each configuration is warmed once and timed three times; the median 95% interval is $\pm$0.8% of the mean with a normal approximation and $\pm$2.0% with Student's t for three timings (90th percentile $\pm$10%). The machine, a two-socket Xeon Gold 6258R (2×28 cores, 38.5 MB LLC per socket, 502 GB RAM; Ubuntu 22.04, kernel 6.8, GCC 11.4), was shared with unrelated workloads, so within-job intervals do not capture the dominant source of variance. All jobs ran pinned to one socket (memory allocated there by first touch) and strictly one at a time, and a fixed single-thread calibration kernel ran before and after every job; a job started only when the kernel reached 380 queries per second (quiet value 500–600; 350 in a later, slower session) on two consecutive checks, and was re-run if it ended below that. Every configuration of the main campaign was measured in two passes and we report the faster one; the second pass and every re-run ran under this gate, whereas part of the first pass predates it (and some of its jobs spanned both sockets), which the best-of-two selection mitigates but does not remove; across the 1073 configurations measured in both passes the median ratio between passes is 1.03 (90th percentile 1.10), and recall is identical across passes for the deterministic methods (the scans, IVF, RIG) and differs by a median of 0.003 (90th percentile 0.016) for ACORN-γ and 0.001 (0.006) for Filtered-DiskANN, whose multi-threaded builds are not deterministic; every reported point keeps the recall and QPS of the same run. Software: Faiss 1.15.1 (AVX2/AVX-512 dispatch), `diskannpy` 0.7.0, hnswlib 0.8.0, and ACORN at commit `c259f11` built with AVX2 and the patch of Section VIII.

IV. A Cost Model for Filtered Search

The cost of answering a filtered k-NN query decomposes into three terms:

$$T = c_{\text{nav}} \cdot H \;+\; c_{\text{chk}} \cdot E \;+\; c_{\text{dist}} \cdot D, \tag{1}$$

where H is the number of navigation steps (graph hops or centroid comparisons), E the number of candidates whose admissibility is checked, and D the number of distance computations to candidates, admissible or not (post-filtering computes them for inadmissible candidates too); c_{dist} is one constant although a batched scan computes distances more cheaply than an index's scattered accesses. The three

method families differ in which terms they can avoid. The exact scan over a label partition has $H{=}E{=}0$ and $D{=}|A_p|$. A predicate-agnostic method—IVF with a bitmap, ACORN, post-filtering—learns whether a candidate is admissible only by checking it, so $E > 0$. A label-indexed structure (a per-label partition, Curator, or the label-partitioned IVF of Section II) never meets an inadmissible candidate, so $E{=}0$ and D is bounded by the admissible points near the query.

Proposition 1 (crossover lower bound). Suppose that admissibility is independent of position (the $\beta{=}0$ workloads) and that a predicate-agnostic method chooses the next candidate to check from positions and from the outcomes of earlier checks only, so that each newly checked candidate is admissible with probability s independently of the past (an idealization: our quantile labels fix each label's size, under which the expected number of checks to the k-th admissible point is $k(n{+}1)/(m{+}1) \approx k/s$). To collect k admissible candidates it checks, in expectation, at least k/s candidates, so $T \geq c_{\text{chk}}\, k/s$, while the scan costs $c_{\text{dist}}\, s\, n$. The method can beat the scan only when $s\, n \geq \sqrt{(c_{\text{chk}}/c_{\text{dist}})\, k\, n}$, that is, a lower bound on the crossover admissible-set size grows as $\sqrt{n}$:

$$m^*(n) \;\geq\; \sqrt{\tfrac{c_{\text{chk}}}{c_{\text{dist}}}\, k\, n}. \tag{2}$$

Proof sketch. Each checked candidate is admissible independently with probability s; the number of checks until the k-th admissible one is negative binomial with mean k/s (Wald's identity gives the same bound for any stopping rule that does not look ahead). Equating the two costs gives the threshold. □

The bound is loose—it ignores navigation and the extra candidates needed for recall—and it does not predict m^* or that the measured crossover grows over any given range of n; it says only that such a method cannot keep a fixed crossover as n grows. For pre- versus post-filtering under a fixed budget B, Mandarapu and Kunkunuru show that both are near-exact over a common selectivity band only when $B \geq \sqrt{kn}$, and observe the crossover selectivity falling as $1/\sqrt{n}$ on synthetic data, with SIFT1M matching [20]; Proposition 1 states it with measured cost constants for every method in its information model, which covers methods that learn admissibility only by checking candidates in a predicate-independent order (IVF with a bitmap, post-filtering, ACORN's checks). Plans that enumerate admissible ids—label partitions, posting lists, Curator's subtrees—are outside it. Section V measures the crossover across n (H1) and whether E and D explain measured time (H2).

Reachability of the admissible subgraph. For an in-filter graph the relevant structure is the subgraph of live admissible nodes that search can traverse, given by each node's *effective admissible out-neighbors* as the search collects them (for ACORN's public code, direct neighbors and neighbors of neighbors beyond the first M_β list positions, until $2M$ are found; the paper truncates at M [1]). When deletions are only excluded through the predicate, deleted nodes keep their slots in these lists, and deletions concentrated on one region remove most of the live neighbors of the admissible nodes that remain there. Our first hypothesis was site percolation, under which the largest component vanishes once the mean effective degree falls to about one (Mandarapu and Kunkunuru measure a static percolation threshold $s_c \approx 0.83/M$, independent of n [20]). Section VI measures effective degree and components per label and round (H3) and finds recall falling well before fragmentation, so the account we test causally, with local repairs, is the reach of search within its budget and the routes into a label's region.

Proposition 2 (rebuild period). Consider a label-specialized index rebuilt every P rounds at cost $B > 0$, with points inserted since the last rebuild answered by an exact scan of a per-label delta. If a query at index age a costs $t_0 + g\, a$—g is the growth of the delta scan per round—then the cost per round with Q queries per round is $B/P + Q\,(t_0 + g\,(P{-}1)/2)$; for $Q, g > 0$ its continuous minimizer is

$$P^* = \sqrt{2B/(Q\, g)}, \tag{3}$$

the classical economic order quantity applied to rebuilds; what the measurements test is whether index aging is linear enough for it to choose the period. Among integer periods, rebuilding every round is optimal only when $Q \geq B/g$ (from $C(1) \leq C(2)$), while the continuous optimum over $P \geq 1$, $\max(1, P^*)$, reaches 1 only at $Q \geq 2B/g$. *Proof.* Differentiate in P, and compare $C(1)$ with $C(2)$. □ Section VII measures $t(a)$ and compares the best period with P^* (H6).

V. Static Filtered Search

A. The exact scan is the baseline to beat (*Q1*)

An exact scan over the admissible points costs time proportional to $s \cdot n$ and nothing else; every index must beat it to be worth its build time, memory, and maintenance.

The crossover grows with n for predicate-agnostic indexes. Proposition 1 bounds m^* from below by a quantity that grows as $\sqrt{n}$; whether m^* itself grows over a given range of n is an empirical question. Figure 1 measures m^* with labels independent of geometry ($\beta{=}0$) for n from 3.16×10^5 to 10^7. At recall 0.95, m^* grows as $n^{0.49}$ for IVF (95% bootstrap interval over queries 0.47–0.52; an interval over queries only; 7 independent label and IVF-training seeds, one run each, give 0.41–0.48 (seed-level 95% interval 0.42–0.46); the other exponents are point estimates, because the batched methods have no per-query times to resample), $n^{0.64}$ for ACORN, and $n^{0.41}$ for post-filtering; at $n{=}10^7$ IVF needs 54,344 admissible points to match the scan, ACORN 180,588, and post-filtering 128,836. The label-indexed structures behave the other way: Curator's m^* does not grow with n ($n^{-0.05}$), and the label-partitioned IVF, which never touches an inadmissible entry, beats the scan at every measured size from 10^3 admissible points up, at every n; at recall 0.99 its m^* is about 10^3 at $n{=}10^7$ (1,004). The bound itself is loose—with the measured cost ratio $c_{\text{chk}}/c_{\text{dist}} \approx 0.052$ it gives $m^* \geq 2,277$ at $n{=}10^7$, more than an order of magnitude below the measured values—but in this DEEP sweep every tested predicate-agnostic index has a positive fitted exponent and Curator a non-positive one, as the bound's separation suggests.

The cost terms account for the time. Across 236 IVF configurations, query time is 0.073 ms plus 5.58 ns per entry checked against the bitmap and 108 ns per admissible distance (R^2=0.967, median relative error 19%, 90th percentile 61%). For ACORN, distance computations alone explain little of the time (R^2=0.426); in the counting build it performs a median of 209 predicate checks per distance computation, and checks and distances together explain its time with R^2=0.980. With independent labels, the number of entries IVF checks per collected neighbor at its cheapest setting with recall ≥ 0.95 grows as $(1/s)^{0.517}$: above the bound's $1/s$ only through the extra lists needed for recall at large s, and approaching it as s falls.

Extrapolation. Fitted on $n \leq 3.16 \times 10^6$, a power law $T = c\,n^a s^b$ predicts throughput at n=10^7 with a median error of 11% for the label-partitioned IVF, 14% for the scan, 42% for ACORN, and 25% for IVF (ACORN reaches the target at only two of the six n=10^7 workloads); IVF's largest errors are at the lowest selectivities, where the check term k/s takes over—a change of regime that a single power law cannot express but the cost decomposition does.

A 4096-dimensional check. On arXiv (β=0, n=10^5..10^6) IVF's crossover again grows as $n^{0.52}$ (95% interval 0.51–0.53), and the label-partitioned IVF beats the scan at every measured size from 10^3 admissible points up, at every n (Curator too, except at the largest admissible sets of the two smaller collections). A distance costs more here relative to a bitmap check ($c_{\text{chk}}/c_{\text{dist}}$=0.016 against 0.052 on DEEP), and, as Proposition 1 implies and as we predicted before the runs, the measured crossover is lower: IVF matches the scan at 3,859 admissible points on arXiv-1M, against 16,375 on DEEP-1M. Two results do not carry over: against the batched scan post-filtering's crossover does not grow with n on these three sizes ($n^{-0.34}$; against a one-query-per-call scan it grows as $n^{0.43}$, so the exception reflects the batched scan's advantage at d=4096), and the cost decomposition fits IVF's time less well (median relative error 34%). On the dataset's real categories (arXiv-1M, median selectivity 0.149), only ACORN reaches recall 0.95, at 11.2× the faster exact scan (the bitmap scan: at d=4096 gathering the admissible rows costs more than scanning in place); IVF, Curator, and post-filtering stop at 0.949, 0.926, and 0.842.

Choosing the threshold. We fix a scan-or-IVF threshold at the crossover measured on DEEP-1M and apply it unchanged, scoring each choice against the faster of the two at recall 0.95. Scaled with $\sqrt{n}$ it never picks the slower method on the other 17 DEEP workloads, while a fixed size or selectivity does on 2, and Milvus's 7% on 5; on the 138 workloads of 6 label and training seeds the calibration never saw, it picks wrong on 4 (at most 21% more cost), a fixed size on 8, and the 7% rule on 32 (up to 788%). On arXiv's 14 workloads it picks wrong on 5 (mean regret 31%); corrected by the square root of the change in $c_{\text{chk}}/c_{\text{dist}}$ from a dataset-free microbenchmark (random vectors, a flat scan with all-false and all-true bitmaps at d=96 and 4096), it picks wrong on 4 with mean regret 5% and at most 23%. We added this correction after seeing the uncorrected result, so it is an exploratory check, not a blind test.

Correlated labels. With β=0.9 the same pattern appears when $s \cdot n$ is held fixed and n grows from 10^6 to 10^7. At 10^4 admissible points the scan wins at every n, and by more as n grows: IVF, the best of the indexes compared there, reaches 0.5× the scan's throughput at recall 0.95 for n=10^6 and 0.1× for n=10^7, and every graph method fails to reach 0.95 at $n \geq 3.16 \times 10^6$; Curator, which indexes each label in its own subtree, does not decline (0.4× and 0.4×). At 10^5 the winner depends on n: IVF is 3.6× faster than the scan at n=10^6 and merely ties it at n=10^7 (1.0×), although with independent labels it still wins there (2.1×). At 10^6 admissible points indexes win: on DEEP-10M at s=0.1 IVF is 4.0× and Filtered-DiskANN 4.0× faster than the scan at recall 0.99, while Curator, designed for selective filters, does not reach 0.95 (maximum recall 0.895), as its authors' advice to pair it with a graph for common labels anticipates [22]. ACORN's larger expansion factor for low selectivity (γ=100 $\geq 1/s$) raises its maximum recall on SIFT1M (s=0.01, β=0.9) only from 0.946 to 0.956, at a build time of 2,144 s instead of 181 s.

When the predicate cannot be pre-partitioned, the exact scan either visits all n rows and tests a bitmap or gathers the admissible rows from an id list (slower at d=4096, below); the *bitmap scan* answers 7.0 QPS on DEEP-10M versus 31 for the per-label partition, so with this bitmap scan arbitrary predicates move the crossover toward smaller admissible sets.

B. Correlation reorders the methods (*Q2*)

Figure 2 varies the label–geometry correlation β on SIFT1M at s=0.1. Post-filtering is among the fastest methods when labels are independent of geometry—854 QPS at 0.99 for β=0 on SIFT1M, within a few percent of IVF (859), and the fastest of all on DEEP-10M (506)—and the worst when they are not: its maximum recall falls to 0.903 at β=0.9 and 0.897 at β=1, because a query's unfiltered neighborhood then contains few admissible points. Filtered-DiskANN moves the other way—from 290 to 913 QPS at 0.99—because its per-label medoids and label-preserving edges sit in the region where a correlated label lives. ACORN and IVF lose throughput as correlation grows (ACORN 721→243, IVF 859→489): for IVF the admissible points of a query's label live in lists far from the query, so more lists must be probed. Curator is insensitive to correlation (maximum recall 0.996 to 0.983, 680 to 667 QPS at 0.95), as a per-label index should be. On both SIFT1M and DEEP-10M, a benchmark that fixes β=0—uniformly random attributes, the common choice [12]—would thus favor post-filtering and penalize the label-specialized graph.

That penalty also depends on where queries lie. In every workload above a query asks for a uniformly random label, so with correlated labels it usually lies far from its label's region. When a query instead asks, with probability ρ, for the label of its nearest neighbor, the ranking at β=0.9 changes: post-filtering, which does not reach recall 0.95 at ρ=0, answers

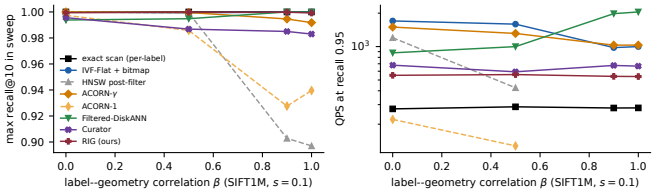


Fig. 2. Effect of label–geometry correlation on SIFT1M (s=0.1): maximum recall reached in each method's sweep (left) and QPS at recall 0.95 (right).

2,519 QPS at ρ=1 and becomes the second-fastest method after the label-partitioned IVF; IVF gains 1.77× and ACORN 1.87×, while Curator falls to 0.601× of its throughput and Filtered-DiskANN barely changes (1.06×). With independent labels ρ matters little (IVF 1.01×, post-filtering 1.28×). A filtered benchmark therefore has to fix two correlations—of attributes with geometry and of queries with their filters—and its conclusions about post-filtering and graph indexes hold only for the second it chose.

C. Real predicates need a dispatcher (*Q3*)

YFCC-10M's queries span four orders of magnitude of selectivity, and none of the indexes we evaluate on them reaches recall 0.99 by itself within its swept parameters. Table II breaks recall down by admissible-set size. The graph methods fail on small admissible sets: ACORN's recall is 0.027 below 10^3 admissible points and 0.190 between 10^3 and 10^4, and reaches 0.995 only above 10^5; RIG, whose entry points are a 1% sample, finds no admissible entry for the most selective queries (0.460); Filtered-DiskANN, which can follow only one tag of an AND and whose rare-tag subgraphs are poorly connected (Section VIII), stays below 0.632 except on the most common tags. IVF degrades least (0.956 below 10^3). Meanwhile the per-query scan answers the smallest bucket at 5,608 QPS.

A common remedy is a selectivity-based dispatcher (ACORN's authors pre-filter below a selectivity of $1/\gamma$ [1]). In its oracle version, queries whose admissible set is smaller than a threshold T go to the exact scan and the rest to the index, with T and the index's parameter tuned jointly (Table II, right). Every method then reaches 0.99; IVF is fastest (311 QPS at T=32,768), ahead of ACORN (231), and the optimal thresholds of IVF, ACORN-γ, post-filtering, and RIG (32,768–65,536) are of the order of the crossover at n=10^7. Applied unchanged to 500 disjoint public queries (a later, slower session), the tuned choices reach recall 0.984–0.994 and keep the methods' order. Routing on cardinalities estimated under tag independence, which underestimates AND queries by a median factor of about 12, misroutes 0 of the 500 queries for IVF: every AND query admits at most 29,090 points, below the threshold, so underestimation moves it further to its side. Curator is exact on selective queries (recall 1.000 below 10^3 admissible points) and weaker on common ones (0.965 above 10^5), so pairing it with another index for common queries—its authors recommend a graph [22]; we also pair it with IVF—is

TABLE II

YFCC-10M (REAL TAGS). LEFT: RECALL BY ADMISSIBLE-SET SIZE $|A|$ AT EACH METHOD'S HIGHEST-RECALL SETTING (QUERIES PER BUCKET IN PARENTHESES). RIGHT: QPS AT THE RECALL TARGET 0.99 WITH A DISPATCHER THAT SCANS QUERIES WITH $|A| < T$, ORACLE (TUNED ON THESE QUERIES) AND HELD-OUT (THE SAME CHOICE ON 500 DISJOINT QUERIES, A LATER SESSION; ACHIEVED RECALL IN PARENTHESES, WHICH CAN FALL BELOW THE TARGET), AND THE HELD-OUT P99 LATENCY IN MS.

	recall by $\|A\|$					dispatched, target recall 0.99		
	$<10^3$ (123)	10^3–10^4 (112)	10^4–10^5 (113)	10^5–10^6 (116)	$\geq 10^6$ (36)	oracle QPS	held-out queries QPS (rec.)	p99 ms
IVF	0.956	0.998	0.999	1.000	1.000	311	228 (0.994)	14.2
ACORN-γ	0.027	0.190	0.777	0.995	1.000	231	176 (0.984)	30.4
ACORN-1	0.015	0.189	0.748	0.980	0.989	82	62 (0.989)	121.1
post-filter	0.435	0.721	0.932	0.997	0.997	200	144 (0.993)	30.4
F-DiskANN	0.093	0.179	0.122	0.632	0.975	37	33 (0.989)	261.3
Curator	1.000	1.000	0.998	0.965	0.953	38	34 (0.988)	261.3
RIG	0.460	0.895	0.991	0.991	0.950	141	113 (0.992)	43.3
scan (per query)	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	11	—	—

the fastest configuration we found (368 QPS with IVF, 346 with ACORN); on the held-out queries the pairings stay faster than scan plus IVF but miss the target slightly (recall 0.989 and 0.985, against 0.994), so their lead there is not at equal recall.

D. Build cost and memory

The methods differ by up to 41× in build time and 10× in memory on DEEP-10M. IVF builds it in 60 s at the size of the data (3.9 GB); ACORN needs 2,109 s (8.9 GB) and Filtered-DiskANN 1,331 s (10.3 GB) on the same 32 threads, and Filtered-DiskANN's build is per label schema, so a new attribute means a new index. ACORN-1 builds 22–23× faster than ACORN-γ but reaches a maximum recall of only 0.928 on SIFT1M and 0.967 on DEEP-10M at s=0.1, β=0.9 (ACORN-γ: 0.995 and 0.985). All build times and sizes are in the artifacts.

E. Inside a database system

Inside a DBMS the optimizer, not the user, picks the access path. We issued the SIFT1M and DEEP-1M n-sweep queries as SQL to PostgreSQL 16 with pgvector 0.8.1, one backend per query. With its default settings the optimizer chooses the HNSW index for 9 of 10 workloads without iterative scans, and the query then returns a recall between 0.012 and 0.939: the index yields the vector's nearest neighbors, the filter discards most of them, and the result is silently short. Only at $|A_p|$=10^3 does it pick the exact plan (B-tree, then sort). Forced into correct plans, the crossover reappears: HNSW with iterative scans overtakes the exact plan at about 13,275 admissible points on DEEP-1M (IVFFlat at 12,625), near IVF's crossover in Faiss at the same n (16,375). In absolute terms the DBMS is far slower: on DEEP-1M at s=0.1 its exact plan answers about 36× fewer queries per second than the per-label scan in Faiss and IVFFlat about 15× fewer than IVF (across sessions; orders of magnitude only). Amanbayev et al. observed that pgvector's optimizer picks approximate index scans where an exact scan gives perfect recall at comparable latency [19], and Lu et al. that, inside a PostgreSQL-compatible system, the page accesses and

tuple lookups behind filter checks dominate filter-first graph search [15]; we quantify the recall the plan choice loses. Milvus 2.6 [30] (standalone, same workloads and parameters) has a dispatcher built in, and it is a fixed rule [18]: its HNSW search falls back to brute force whenever at least 93% of a segment's rows are filtered out, i.e. below a per-segment selectivity of 7% at any n (also when k is large relative to the admissible rows, and it repeats a search by brute force when the graph returns fewer than k). On DEEP-1M this brute force, a bitmap pass over the segment, answers 70.9–97.7 QPS at $s \leq 3.1\%$, while IVF_FLAT in the same server reaches recall 0.95 at 163–186 QPS there, 1.67–2.49× faster down to 10^3 admissible points, so at this n the threshold is too high. Its default search parameters give recall 0.860–0.906 on the graph path, and a search takes 3.78 ms even on a one-row collection (median).

F. Multi-threaded throughput

We repeated three workloads with 28 search threads on one socket's physical cores, in each method's better mode (its native batched call or 28 threads of single-query calls), the better of two passes, against single-thread runs from the same session. ACORN scales 16.1–17.4×, post-filtering 16.7×, IVF 10.9–13.7×, RIG 5.9–7.2×, and the scan 5.4–10.1×, while a thread pool of Filtered-DiskANN's per-query calls is slower than one thread; post-filtering becomes the fastest method on DEEP-10M with β=0 (14,760 QPS at recall 0.95) and ACORN overtakes IVF on SIFT1M (15,489 versus 11,399). The crossover rises with threads: at n=10^7 with independent labels, IVF's m^* at recall 0.95 grows from 54,344 to 143,307 and ACORN's from 180,588 to 234,677, because near the crossover the scan's speed-up exceeds IVF's by 2.9–3.6× (and equals it below 10^4 admissible points; each speed-up compares two sessions, the ratio of two speed-ups cancels the session), while post-filtering's m^* falls and the label-partitioned IVF still wins at 10^3. Which method is fastest therefore depends on whether queries are served one at a time or batched across cores; the stream comparisons that follow are single-threaded.

VI. FILTERED SEARCH UNDER UPDATES (**Q4**)

Table III summarizes the last round of the three synthetic streams (per-round curves are in the artifacts). We group the methods by the update paths of Table I.

Exact deletion (scan, IVF, RIG). The per-label scan and IVF delete by removing entries, so nothing accumulates. IVF holds a maximum recall of 1.000 on SIFT-500K after 200% turnover and 1.000 on DEEP-5M after 100%, at nearly unchanged throughput (2,444→2,321 and 557→546 QPS at recall 0.95), for a total maintenance of 1.2 s and 12.4 s—cheaper than every other index of that session (Curator needs 5–9× as much, and the graph indexes two to three orders of magnitude more). RIG also deletes exactly (maximum recall $\geq$0.998 throughout) at 38–39× IVF's maintenance.

Curator deletes by revoking a point's labels, which removes it from the per-label subtrees although its vector stays in the shared tree; its quality also stays flat (maximum recall 0.987 on SIFT-500K and 0.990 under correlated deletions, 0.916 on DEEP-5M, where it never reaches 0.95), at 5–9× IVF's maintenance.

Deletion through the predicate (ACORN, post-filtering). ACORN has no deletion routine; deleted points stay in the graph and are excluded by the query bitmap. Its graph therefore grows (3.0× resident nodes on SIFT-500K) and every deletion lowers the density of live admissible points that in-filter navigation must traverse. Under uniform deletions its maximum recall drifts from 1.000 to 0.993 and its throughput at recall 0.95 from 1,855 to 656; on DEEP-5M it reaches 0.99 at round 0 but not at the later measured rounds (5 and 10), and its throughput at 0.95 falls from 427 to 197, while its incremental insertions cost 119× IVF's maintenance. *Correlated* deletions are far worse: when the stream deletes the geometric region of the highest labels (SIFT-500K-adv), ACORN's maximum recall collapses from 1.000 to 0.970 after four rounds and 0.575 after twenty. A control separates the update path from the data: rebuilt from scratch on exactly the live points, labels, and queries of round 20, ACORN reaches a maximum recall of 0.995 (1,300 QPS at recall 0.95) on the correlated-deletion stream and 1.000 on the uniform one, against 0.575 and 0.993 for the incrementally maintained graph. The collapse and the drift therefore come from ACORN's update history, not from the live set; a rebuild also changes insertion order, so which part of that history matters is left to the instrumented runs below. Post-filtering with slot reuse keeps its recall under uniform churn but is slow at high recall (273 QPS at 0.95 on SIFT-500K) and capped by the correlated predicate on DEEP-5M (maximum recall 0.913); under correlated deletions it loses ground (0.990→0.964).

What collapses. Section IV predicts that in-filter search fails when the subgraph of live admissible nodes thins out. The instrumented streams record, per label and round, the mean number of live admissible out-neighbors ACORN's level-0 search can collect from a node (its *effective degree*) and the share of the label's live nodes in the largest connected component of that subgraph (Figure 3). A label's maximum recall tracks its effective degree (0.997 at 16 or more, 0.643 between 4 and 8, 0.061 below 2). The collapse sets in near a degree of five rather than one, and before the subgraph fragments: labels with recall below 0.5 still keep a mean share of 0.704 of their live nodes in one component. Recall thus falls before the largest *weakly* connected component breaks up. Directed reachability does explain it: replaying ACORN's filtered descent exactly and searching the admissible subgraph from the entry it reaches, the share of a label's live nodes reachable tracks the label's recall (Spearman 0.92; on average 0.57 reachable and recall 0.57 with tombstones). A local repair that rewires each live node's level-0 list around its deleted neighbors (Section III) tests the mechanism: on SIFT-500K-adv it keeps maximum recall at 0.991 through round 12, against 0.670 without it, for 1.20–1.26× the maintenance of tombstones, but then falls again (0.878–0.982 at round 20 over 5 runs, against 0.546–0.615 with tombstones alone), and the labels that fail have dense, connected level-0 subgraphs (mean

effective degree 15.8) and still about 156 live nodes above level 0. ACORN filters its upper levels too, and this repair leaves their lists pointing at deleted nodes, which can cut the route from the entry point into the label's region. Repairing every level supports this account (reachable share 0.99, against 0.63 when only the upper levels are repaired): maximum recall then stays at 0.995 at round 12 and 0.997–0.998 at round 20 in each of 5 runs—as high as a fresh build on the same live data—for 1.10–1.15× the maintenance of tombstones alone in the same session. ACORN's collapse is thus a property of its update path that a local consolidation removes, not of in-filter search. Measured again next to IVF in a later session (Table III), the repair is no general cure: it leaves recall unchanged under uniform deletions on SIFT-500K and lowers it on DEEP-5M (0.943 against 0.983 with tombstones; over 4 runs of three stream seeds, the drop is -0.044 to -0.032), although a fresh build on the same live set reaches 0.994.

What the repair changes. Two variants test the repair policy. Repairing only the upper levels leaves the correlated-deletion collapse in place (0.623–0.628 on SIFT-500K-adv), so the level-0 lists must be repaired as well as the routes into them. Our repair re-ranks all candidates of a node that lost a neighbor and keeps the nearest; under uniform deletions, which touch nearly every node, it keeps 93% of a node's live neighbors but 83% of its long ones. That shortening does not explain the harm label by label (Spearman 0.03; the pre-registered test fails), but reachability does, in an exploratory analysis: re-ranking leaves 0.91 of a label reachable (slot-filling: 0.99), and the recall loss tracks the loss of the true neighbors' reachability (Spearman 0.77). Keeping a node's live neighbors in place and refilling only the deleted slots—the one policy changed—removes the harm on DEEP-5M (0.987, 278–299 QPS at recall 0.95, where re-ranking never reaches it) and reaches 1,301–1,372 QPS in SIFT-500K's last round (re-ranking, in an earlier session: 637), while still recovering most of the correlated collapse (0.983–0.988 against 0.998 with re-ranking). Where it restores recall, the re-ranking repair needs 255× IVF's maintenance for 621 against IVF's 1,795 QPS.

Synchronous repair (EMA). EMA repairs edges and Markers inside every deletion, and it holds maximum recall at ≥0.999 on every stream, including the correlated one where tombstoned ACORN collapses. The failure moves to throughput instead: on SIFT-500K-adv EMA answers 1,455 QPS at recall 0.95 before the deletions and 272 after 20 rounds (5.3× fewer, median over passes; IVF in the same session: 1.3×), against 1.8× under uniform deletions, at 408–440× IVF's maintenance on the SIFT streams.

A real temporal stream. On arXiv in time order (4096 dimensions, real categories, a sliding window that deletes the oldest papers) the ranking reverses. Graph indexes answer 7.2–8.4× (EMA) and, in their own session, 5.7–6.4× (ACORN) IVF's QPS at recall 0.95 in the last round, which is consistent with a distance costing far more than a navigation step at d=4096 (the data, labels, query–filter relation, and deletion order differ from the synthetic streams as well), and none collapses: deleting by age does not empty a label's region

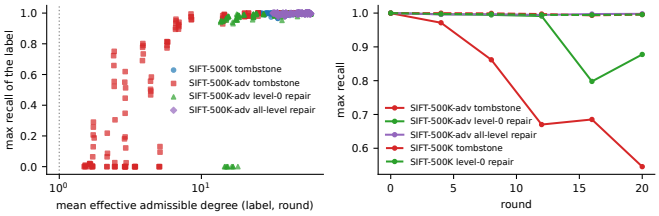


Fig. 3. ACORN under deletions excluded through the predicate. Left: maximum recall of a label's queries against the mean effective admissible degree of its live nodes (one point per label and measured round). Right: maximum recall by round with tombstones only, with a local repair of level 0, and with a repair of every level.

TABLE III
LAST ROUND OF EACH STREAM: MAXIMUM RECALL / QPS AT RECALL 0.95 (1 THREAD; N/R: NOT REACHED) / TOTAL MAINTENANCE (S, 16 THREADS; FILTERED-DISKANN: ONE REBUILD PER ROUND). *LATER SESSIONS, WITH IVF RERUN ALONGSIDE (TWO PASSES, BEST PER CELL AS FOR THE OTHER ROWS).

	SIFT-500K, round 20			DEEP-5M, round 10			SIFT-500K-adv, round 20		
	rec.	QPS	maint.	rec.	QPS	maint.	rec.	QPS	maint.
exact scan	1.000	859	2.7	1.000	62	16.7	1.000	550	2.5
label-part. IVF*	0.999	6,922	0.8	0.999	2,544	5.8	1.000	5,261	0.9
IVF	1.000	2,321	1.2	1.000	546	12.4	0.999	1,866	1.2
post-filter	0.991	273	246.0	0.913	n/r	1,565.4	0.964	109	208.7
ACORN-γ	0.993	656	276.1	0.982	197	1,481.1	0.575	n/r	275.1
all-level repair*	0.994	637	345	0.943	n/r	1,843	0.998	621	310
EMA*	1.000	848	535	1.000	101	2,753	1.000	272	508
F-DiskANN	0.999	2,490	1,043	0.996	828	8,197	1.000	3,771	1,084
Curator	0.987	885	9.7	0.916	n/r	57.5	0.990	1,498	11.1
RIG	1.000	724	46.1	0.999	202	486.5	0.999	578	46.1

(ACORN's maximum recall stays ≥0.998). IVF, whose centroids were trained on the oldest window, loses throughput as the topics drift (240→130 QPS, the label-partitioned IVF 639→188); retraining every five rounds recovers it (271 QPS) for 4.4× IVF's maintenance (ACORN: 169×). The update time is that of the paper's latest version, and the queries are 500 later papers, fixed across rounds: a stress test of drift rather than a replay of arXiv's traffic.

Rebuild (Filtered-DiskANN). Freshly rebuilt, Filtered-DiskANN is the fastest method of the first session at recall 0.95 in the last round of all three synthetic streams (2,490 QPS on SIFT-500K, 828 on DEEP-5M, 3,771 on SIFT-500K-adv; at 0.99, 948 versus IVF's 1,188 on SIFT-500K), but each rebuild takes 52 s and 820 s on 16 threads, so staying fresh every round costs 1,043 s and 8,197 s—861× and 659× IVF's maintenance. Between rebuilds, inserted points are invisible to it.

Scan throughput. The scan stays exact, and its throughput tracks the live admissible-set sizes (under correlated deletions 864→550 QPS).

VII. TOTAL COST (Q5)

A deployment pays for maintenance and for queries. For a stream of R rounds with U updates and Q filtered queries per round, method X costs $M_X + Q\sum_r t_{X,r}$: its maintenance after the initial build plus its per-query time at the recall target in each round, interpolated between measured rounds. Figure 4 plots this cost against Q/U, relative to IVF in the

same session, for every method that holds recall 0.95 at every measured round of every run; the others are named in each panel. On the three synthetic streams the label-partitioned IVF is the cheapest at every tested query rate (0.22–0.39× IVF). Among the predicate-agnostic methods IVF is cheaper than ACORN, post-filtering, Curator, EMA, and RIG at every tested rate on these streams; only a Filtered-DiskANN rebuilt every round undercuts it, from 3 queries per update on DEEP-5M and 10 on SIFT-500K-adv, where IVF slows down as deletions empty regions. The arXiv stream reverses the order with the query rate: the label-partitioned IVF is cheapest at 0.1 queries per update (0.59× IVF), and from one query per update the graph indexes are, whose per-query advantage outweighs maintenance two orders of magnitude above IVF's; EMA is lowest (0.43× at 1, 0.19× at 100), also in each of 4 further blocks that ran every method in random order between two IVF anchors, 5–17% below repaired ACORN. The costs exclude the initial build, which a deployment pays once; including it changes the cheapest method in 0 of the 36 stream–rate cells. Timing queries end to end (predicate state kept current as maintenance, result filtering and id mapping inside the query timer) changes the cheapest method in none of the 36 cells (Table IV). Memory, which follows the update path (ACORN grows with the deleted nodes it keeps), is not costed.

Executed rebuild periods. Between rebuilds, an exact per-label scan of the points inserted since the last build keeps them visible (Proposition 2). We executed this design on both SIFT streams for $P \in \{1, 2, 3, 4, 6, 10, 20\}$ rounds, measuring every round (P=20 never rebuilds within the stream; 2 runs per period). With the search effort chosen per round from the ground truth (an oracle), every period holds recall 0.95 on both streams, and the period that Proposition 2 computes from the *other* stream's rebuild time and delta growth costs at most 6.8% more than the best executed period in either run; re-estimating B and g from these runs instead changes the chosen period in 1 of 6 cases. A search effort fixed on the other stream does not transfer as well: L=64, enough on SIFT-500K-adv, misses 0.95 on SIFT-500K for 6 of the 7 periods in both runs, in up to 19 of 20 rounds. At a target of 0.90 every period holds it with that L, and the transferred period costs at most 8.0% more than the best. The period transfers between these two streams; the effort that holds a recall target must be checked on the stream itself.

VIII. Lessons for Evaluating Filtered Search (**Q6**)

A shared machine and eleven methods from seven code bases surfaced failure modes of the *evaluation* as much as of the methods.

Machine contention. Our calibration kernel varied between 6 and 634 queries per second over the 25 days of our measurements, while repetitions inside a job varied by a few percent. In one early pass the scan and IVF arms of seven SIFT workloads ran at a quarter of the kernel's quiet value and, re-run, were up to 2.9× faster, enough to reverse which method wins at $s \cdot n = 10^5$; hence the protocol of Section III.

Defects and limits of baseline implementations. ACORN's incremental `add` writes one entry past a full upper-level neighbor list and corrupts the graph (we truncate to capacity, as Faiss HNSW does), and its documented build compiles scalar kernels (our AVX2 build searches 1.1–1.4× faster at identical recall); `diskannpy` pads short filtered results with uninitialized identifiers; and Filtered-DiskANN with one label per point stays below recall 0.2 at s=0.01 (at most 0.168 on SIFT1M and 0.174 on DEEP-10M), as a user report finds for the C++ tools [31] and recent benchmarks attribute to its search [22], [13].

Harness pitfalls. Two of our own bugs changed conclusions before we caught them (a stale index sized its request by overall rather than per-label survival; Milvus indexes were built while segments still merged); both runs are kept, with their reasons, among the superseded results. Re-inserted duplicates charge a method a miss for returning a live copy of its target (our streams use distinct BIGANN descriptors), and every measured number in this paper is a macro generated from the analysis output.

Interpolation decides close comparisons. QPS at a recall target is interpolated between the two bracketing measured points, which on doubling grids differ by a median factor of 1.69 in QPS for IVF (3.29 for post-filtering); in 30 of 177 index-versus-scan comparisons the verdict changes between them. Re-measured with knob steps of $\sqrt{2}$, 20 of the 23 covered verdicts stand and 3 reverse (2 within 5% of one; ACORN's on SIFT1M from 1.12 to 0.911); claims that rest on a factor below the bracket should be measured. Best-of-two raises QPS over the mean of two passes by a median 1.03× for the scan and 1.01–1.02× for the graphs, and rarely changes a verdict (Table IV).

Simple baselines. The exact scan (on DEEP faster than every predicate-agnostic index at $s \cdot n \leq 10^4$), IVF with a bitmap (competitive static, cheap to maintain), a label-partitioned IVF where labels are known at build time, and a dispatcher (needed for recall 0.99 on YFCC) each changed a conclusion here; evaluations should report them.

IX. Limitations and Threats to Validity

Measurement. All results come from one shared machine. The gating protocol of Section III removes runs taken under gross contention, but part of the first pass predates the gate, and differences below the pass-to-pass spread (90th percentile 1.10×) should not be over-read. The machine's single-thread speed also varied between sessions (by about a third in the last session); every ratio we report is therefore formed within one session, and throughputs from different sessions are compared only by their ranking. The cost frontier combines such ratios across sessions, assuming that session effects are alike across methods. With 500 queries per workload the standard error of mean recall has a median of 0.0017 and a maximum of 0.009 for configurations at recall ≥ 0.95, and reaches 0.022 for the low-recall YFCC configurations.

Tuning on the reported queries. Sweeps and the dispatcher's threshold are evaluated on the reported queries, as is

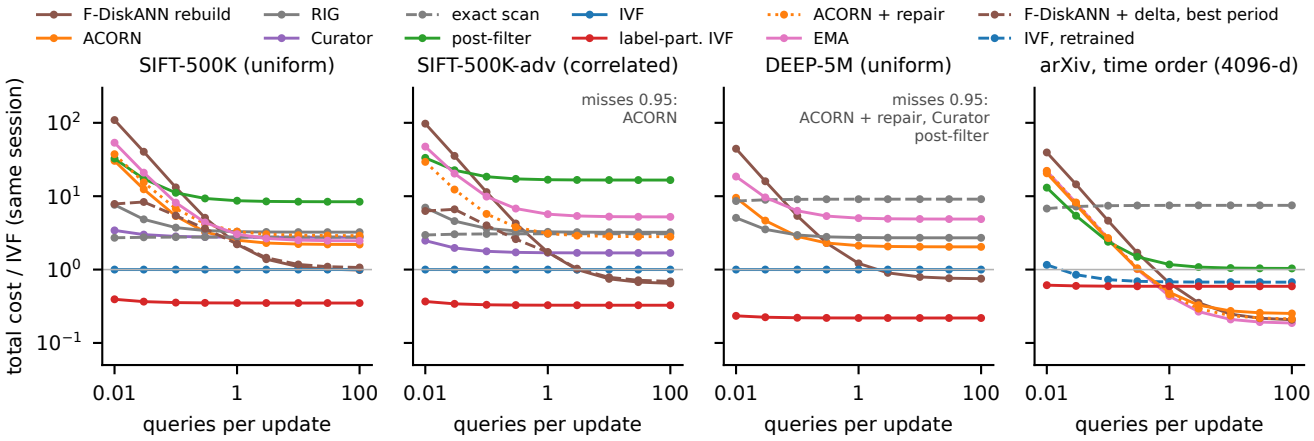


Fig. 4. Total cost (maintenance after the initial build plus queries at recall 0.95, per-query time interpolated between measured rounds) relative to IVF in the same session, against queries per update. A method appears only if it reaches 0.95 at every measured round of every run; the others are named. Medians over runs; rebuild policies use the per-round oracle effort.

customary; applied unchanged to 500 disjoint YFCC queries, the dispatcher's choices reach a recall of 0.984–0.994 at the 0.99 target. Reported operating points are therefore optimistic, not necessarily by the same amount for every method.

Workloads. Synthetic labels are quantiles of one random projection, one per point; real predicates come from YFCC-10M's tags and arXiv's categories; k=10 throughout. In the three synthetic streams insertions follow the base distribution, so IVF's centroids meet no drift; the arXiv stream, a stress test of real drift, shows IVF losing throughput without retraining. Synthetic deletions are either uniform or concentrated along one direction; arXiv deletes the oldest papers.

What is not timed. Predicate evaluation is excluded: with our numpy path it costs 3.2 ms per YFCC query, about as much as the dispatched IVF search (99%), while an AND of Roaring bitmaps takes 0.026 ms (0.266 ms with the admissible ids), so it is a property of the attribute index and is reported separately; the end-to-end check of Table IV times per-label bitmaps kept current by the updates.

Implementations and coverage. We evaluate public implementations through their native or Python interfaces (Filtered-DiskANN through `diskannpy`, which has no dynamic filtered index; ACORN with our patch, AVX2, γ=12). We do not evaluate range-filter structures, label or predicate indexes whose released code has no update path (UNG, NHQ, CAPS, SIEVE), EMA on static workloads, database systems other than PostgreSQL and Milvus, or disk-resident indexes; Curator runs with its authors' YFCC parameters; updates and queries alternate by round except in one concurrency test (Table IV).

Explanations and scope of claims. The cost model's terms are measured for IVF and ACORN (Section V-A); for the other methods the crossover's growth rests on fitted exponents over four sizes of one dataset (on arXiv IVF's exponent recurs), and Proposition 1 is a bound under independent labels, not a prediction of m^*. Table cells (as Table III) report the better of two passes, the cost frontier each run whole. The bootstrap intervals resample queries only; across passes IVF's exponent moves by at most 0.02, across seeds by 0.41–0.48. The study began as the evaluation of a new index, and its questions followed when simple baselines proved competitive. The follow-up campaign's hypotheses were stated with falsification criteria before it ran: operationalizing Proposition 1 as an exponent of at least 0.5, ACORN's estimate (0.64) exceeds it, IVF's seed-level interval (0.42–0.46) lies below it, and post-filtering's (0.41) fails, so the data support the bound and the exponent's sign, not a $\sqrt{n}$ law. The entry-point test, the all-level repair, the dense sweeps, and the PostgreSQL, Milvus, and arXiv experiments were added after first results and are exploratory; the predicted effects of cardinality-estimation error and best-of-two selection were not found. A second follow-up (Table IV) was pre-registered with its decision rules in the artifact before its runs; of its two mechanism accounts one held and one failed.

Conflict of interest. RIG is the author's own, unpublished design. It was developed on SIFT1M and DEEP with the query sets used here, which may favor it; we report its losses and draw no conclusion that depends on it.

X. Related Work

Experimental studies of filtered search. The closest studies evaluate filtered search on static data. Zhu et al. [11] evaluate fifteen hybrid-query algorithms on up to 10^8 points, with dynamic insertion only in their taxonomy; like those of Li, Shi, and Iff et al., their experiments use static data without controlled attribute–vector correlation. Li et al. [12] compare twelve attribute-filtering methods on four datasets of up to 10^7 vectors (two with real labels), and note that their methods rarely support updates. Shi et al. [13] benchmark ten label-filter methods on six real datasets with unified tuning, including pre-filter brute force and post-filtered IVF-PQ; Iff et al. [14] contribute transformer embeddings with eleven attributes. Inside a PostgreSQL-compatible engine, Lu et al. [15]

TABLE IV
PRE-REGISTERED FOLLOW-UP CHECKS (DECISION RULES FIXED BEFORE THE RUNS; ONE RUN PER CELL UNLESS STATED)

check	outcome
crossover, 7 seeds	IVF exponent 0.41–0.48, seed-level 95% interval 0.42–0.46
threshold, 6 unseen seeds	wrong of 138: $\sqrt{n}$-scaled 4 (regret $\leq$21%), fixed size 8, fixed selectivity 16, 7% 32 ($\leq$788%)
SIMD level (Faiss)	$c_{\mathrm{chk}}/c_{\mathrm{dist}}$ moves only to 0.041; wrong of 23: $\sqrt{n}$ 1, 0; 7% 5, 6
repair, DEEP-5M, 6 runs	recall change -0.044 to -0.020 over 5 stream seeds, negative in every run
repair mechanism	entry account held (reach–recall ρ=0.92); long-edge account failed (ρ=0.03)
arXiv cost, 4 blocks	random method order between two IVF runs; from 1 query per update graphs beat label-part. IVF and EMA is cheapest in every block (0.37–0.43$\times$ IVF); ACORN 0.45–0.66$\times$; IVF drift $\leq$23%
rebuild period, 2 runs	regret $\leq$6.8%; fixed L misses 0.95 in 6/7 periods in both runs
end-to-end timing	cheapest method changes in 0 of 36 cells; relative cost moves $\leq$19%
concurrent updates	1 writer, 8 readers, SIFT and SIFT-adv; p99 over quiet: IVF, one lock 8.9, 6.3$\times$; label-part. IVF, per-label locks 1.3, 1.4$\times$; post-filtering 1.1, 1.0$\times$; EMA 2.7, 20.8$\times$; no stale result
multi-label stream	YFCC tags, AND, 10 rounds; 0.95 held by the exact scan and by EMA, 13–28$\times$ slower with 3.2 h of maintenance; maximum recall IVF 0.94, post-filtering 0.73, ACORN 0.48$\rightarrow$0.38
second temporal stream	Amazon reviews, 384-d: label-part. IVF cheapest up to 1 query per update (arXiv: 0.3), EMA from 3, as predicted
half-query tuning; mean or worse pass	0/71 index-vs-scan verdicts change on the held-out half; 3 and 4 of 207 change with the mean or worse pass
re-execution, 132 random jobs	recall identical for deterministic methods (111/111 files), within tolerance for 221/236 others (misses: ACORN stream repairs, pgvector IVFFlat); QPS ratio median 1.01 (p10–p90 0.94–1.12); 238/254 pairwise verdicts agree

vary selectivity and correlation and find that system overheads and filter checks change which method wins; Amanbayev et al. [19] compare Faiss, Milvus, and pgvector and find IVF-Flat ahead of HNSW at low selectivity; Lim et al. [32] argue that selectivity and correlation are unstable proxies for hardness; Sanca and Ailamaki [33] characterize scan-versus-index access paths; and the winning Big-ANN'23 filtered entry already chose between a linear scan and a graph by tag cardinality [16]. Chronis et al.'s tutorial [34] surveys the area; Mandarapu and Kunkunuru model plan choice as a phase transition in selectivity, with a budget threshold at $\sqrt{kn}$ [20], and FAVOR routes queries by estimated selectivity [35], both on static data. We do not claim the first scan or IVF baseline, the first controlled correlation, or the $1/\sqrt{n}$ scaling of the crossover selectivity [20]; we add the joint treatment of filters and updates, the crossover's growth across index families and systems, and the correlated-deletion failure and its repair.

Streaming ANN. The Big-ANN'23 streaming track evaluates insert/search/delete runbooks without filters, and CANDY [17] benchmarks continuous ingestion. Index papers evaluate their own update paths: FreshDiskANN [8], SPFresh [9], in-place DiskANN updates [10], and incremental IVF maintenance [36]; Xiao et al. [37] document unreachable points in HNSW under replaced updates, and Yamashita et al. [38] formalize logical deletion, physical deletion, and rebuilding in graph indexes and propose how to evaluate them. MERIT repairs graph indexes in place on deletion, without filters [39]; Mandarapu and Kunkunuru find signal-triggered repair no better than scheduled repair at a matched budget [40]; and Das et al. separate staleness from filtered navigability in per-tenant recall under concurrent updates [41]. Dynamic *filtered* indexes exist—DIGRA [42], the dynamic range-filter index of Zhang et al. [43], DSG [44], WoW [45], Curator [22] (which we evaluate), and EMA [24]—but their update experiments are narrower than churn: DSG and WoW only insert, DIGRA and the index of Zhang et al. apply insertion-only or deletion-only batches, Curator reports update latency, and EMA measures only itself. VecBench [46] runs several vector databases through insert, update, and delete phases but reports them as latencies. We know of no study that tracks the recall and throughput of several filtered methods, with exact-scan and IVF baselines, while insertions and deletions interleave, or that varies how deletions correlate with the attribute.

Methods not evaluated. Range-filter structures (SeRF [5], iRangeGraph [6], UNIFY [7], window filters [47]) target range predicates; label-centric methods include NHQ [4], UNG [3], and CAPS [48]; SIEVE [49] tunes a collection of indexes for arbitrary predicates; NaviX [50] targets general predicates inside a graph DBMS, and Compass [51] combines vector and B$^+$-tree indexes for DBMS integration. We restrict the study to methods whose released code supports updates under label or arbitrary predicates; among database systems we evaluate PostgreSQL and Milvus, not graph DBMSs such as Kuzu.

XI. CONCLUSION

Our measurements suggest four guidelines, each with the conditions under which it held. *(i)* Keep an exact pre-filter scan, and set the dispatch threshold for the collection size, threads, and hardware at hand: scaled with $\sqrt{n}$ it transferred across DEEP sizes and seeds (arXiv, exploratory, needed a cost-ratio correction), a fixed selectivity did not. *(ii)* Measure both correlations—attributes with embeddings, and queries with their filters—before choosing between post-filtering and a filter-aware index. *(iii)* Choose the index for a stream by its total cost at the target recall over the expected ratio of queries to updates, not by query speed: on our synthetic single-label streams a label-partitioned IVF was cheapest at every tested ratio, on the drifting 4096-dimensional arXiv stream graph indexes were from about one query per update, and IVF needed retraining there. *(iv)* Judge an update path by recall *and* throughput over the stream: tombstones lost recall under correlated deletions, a repair of every level restored it but hurt under uniform ones when it re-ranked live neighbors (refilling only deleted slots did not), and EMA's synchronous deletion kept recall but lost throughput. Open problems: deletion paths that recover from correlated deletions without harming uniform ones, and dispatchers that adapt to n, threads, and drift. Artifacts with per-query results: https://github.com/suanlab/filtered-ann-updates-bench.

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Use of AI-generated content. In accordance with the IEEE policy on AI-generated content, we disclose that AI systems were used substantially in this work, through the Claude Code agent: Claude Opus 5 and Claude Fable 5 (Anthropic; August–September 2026) for the design of RIG, its kernels, and early experiments; Claude Opus 4.8 (September 2026) for revisions of that work; and Claude Opus 5.5 (October 2026) for everything else listed here. They implemented the harness, workload generators, baseline drivers and patches, and RIG (Sections II–III); ran and analyzed the experiments (Sections V–VII); generated every figure and table from the raw results; they identified the implementation defects reported in Section VIII; at the author's request they proposed the cost model of Section IV, the hypotheses of the follow-up campaign with their falsification criteria, and the experiments that test them, which the author approved before they were run; they drafted the text of all sections; and AI agents, including Codex (OpenAI), performed internal reviews and audits of the manuscript, code, and results. The human author defined the research questions, made the design and scope decisions, reviewed every result and revision, and takes full responsibility for the content. No AI system is listed as an author.

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